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California vs Trump: Attorney Gen. Bonta lays out "Resistance" plan

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During an online conference on Feb. 26, California Attorney General Rob Bonta detailed how the Trump Administration had used its first five and a half weeks to execute an agenda that runs counter in various ways to California state policies and priorities.

Since taking office, President Donald Trump has issued scores of executive actions that make good on many of his campaign promises. Bonta said the impact of Trump's exercise of his powers is creeping up on the doorsteps of California's diverse residents.

"People are scared, worried, anxious, and uncertain about what's happening in the federal government and if it will impact their lives and loved ones," Bonta said. "Sadly, I think it's pretty clear that that's part of the president's strategy: To flood the zone, overwhelm us with a barrage of damaging, dangerous, and illegal executive orders and actions that impede on the law and values that make America strong." Bonta made the statement while delivering an address as the guest speaker of a virtual conference hosted by Capitol Weekly, a non-partisan publication focused on California politics.

"The Resistance: California vs. Donald Trump." The 4 hour event explored Trump's presidential executive orders, mass firings, deportations, and billionaire Elon Musk's handling of the Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE).

One of the directives Trump signed on Jan. 21 bans diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) policies in the federal government and urges the private sector to follow suit. Some corporations such as Amazon, Target, and Walmart have eliminated or scaled back their DEI programs.

Bonta had already advised California businesses, nonprofits, and other entities not to sway from DEI initiatives in their workplaces. "I urge all California businesses not to fall for this scare tactic," Bonta stated. The online conference was held almost three weeks after Gov. Gavin Newsom signed two bills appropriating $50 million to "Trump Proof" the state of California. It provides Bonta and the California Department of Justice (DOJ) funding to file lawsuits against the Trump Administration as well as protect California laws, institutions, and policies, Bonta said. The funding is two-fold. First, Senate Bill SBX1-1, authored by Scott Weiner (D-San Francisco) and Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) amends the 2024 Budget Act to include a State Litigation Fund, distributing $25 million to the DOJ. SBX-1 was enacted in case the Trump Administration decides to withhold funding for emergency aid after a natural disaster such as the wildfires that occurred in Los Angeles. The DOJ says it intends to go after the federal government in courts if aid is withheld.

The second bill that was born out of the Special Legislative Session called by Newsom, SBX1-2, amends the Budget Act to add funding for Legal Services, including $25 million for legal assistance for Californians and immigrant communities.

Authored by Weiner and Gabriel, SBX1-2, also allows the DOJ to provide free legal services for veterans, people with disabilities, homeless youth, families facing eviction, seniors, victims of domestic violence, wage theft, and human trafficking.

Bonta stated that the funding is sufficient and that his office is staffed to handle litigation that resists obstructive policies and interference from the Trump Administration.

The funds would be used "wisely and prudently and efficiently," Bonta said.

"I am here to provide facts, reasons, and assurances of California's nation-leading protections," Bonta said. "I am here to enforce our laws, defend our rights, and protect our people. I am here to ensure progress prevails in California." To continue reading, please visit cablackmedia.org.

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